conference of development banks in Asia on March 29, 1962—the first such conference ever to be organized.

ICICI soon acquired an enviable reputation as a leading development bank and the high quality of its staff was by now widely acknowledged. George Woods, President of the World Bank, requested the ICICI for the services of James Raj for the Development Bank in Nigeria, R.K. Chari was deputed to the Malaysian Industrial Development Bank, and M.C. Shetty to the Asian Development Bank. During these years both George Woods and Robert McNamara visited India and had discussions with ICICI. ICICI also took initiatives to cultivate better relations with its clients by organizing conferences so that they could appreciate their problems better and discuss the various factors which influenced ICICI's decisions on project financing.

AN ERA ENDS

G.L. Mehta retired in 1973 and an era came to an end. He was succeeded by Parekh, the quiet professional who now became the public face of ICICI. The Board of ICICI passed a resolution at a meeting held on May 9, 1974, in which it recalled that Mehta had brought to its activities a sense of purpose and mission which helped to make ICICI a highly respected institution. He also contributed to the growth of ICICI by building up its relationship with the Government of India, RBI, and other financial institutions. Mehta also helped restore the confidence of the World Bank in ICICI and its role in the Indian economy. As a result, ICICI obtained continuing support in the form of loans from the World Bank. In addition, his informality and easy accessibility ensured the loyalty and full co-operation of his staff.

But despite his suave manners and tactful behavior, Mehta was one of the toughest negotiators in the business. James S. Raj recalls, 'I have never come across another man who could say 'no' with such pleasantness as he could. I had the privilege of accompanying him to Washington in 1963 to negotiate a World Bank loan for ICICI and I can never forget the manner in which he sailed with ease through the many shoals which had been fixed for him by the 'Reception Committee' on the other side of the table. In fact if I remember rightly, the final negotiations in which G.L. met the President of